

to give them a valid e-mail ID so they can sell your information—usually to a spammer. So you should either never give out your e-mail address to porn sites, or be prepared for thousands of spam mails a day. You could always create an e-mail ID meant only for spam, and use that to sign up, if you must.

Credit cards: “Free” content is offered by several porn sites, which urge you to enter your credit card information to “verify your age.” You need to stay away from doing this, and go looking for free sites with the content you want instead. Your credit card information could be leaked, and you could get some strange bills. Even at “trusted” (read notorious) porn sites, you have to read the fine print before you go about entering your credit card number. Very often, the word “free” is misrepresented: if you read the fine print, you’ll see that the content is only free for the first three days or so, after which your card is automatically charged for a month’s worth of access. This could be for a shorter or longer duration, but you *will* be charged. If you’re using daddy’s credit card, you’re going to have a lot of explaining to do.

Chat rooms: People are almost never really who they claim to be in chat rooms. That 16-year-old girl you think you’re falling for could well be a 61-year-old male. Don’t give out any personal information online, such as your telephone number or address. Girls and women need to be especially careful about who they fraternize with online!

Web cameras: This is the age of broadband, and everyone now seems to have a Webcam. Yahoo! Messenger is especially popular for its chat rooms and liberally-used Webcams. A lot of people use pre-recorded feeds from some pornographic Web cam site to pretend to be women, and in turn will ask young males to turn on their Webcams and indulge in “cam sex.” Either they’re trying to get you to pay to see more, to cam with a real woman, or they’re recording you and selling your video to homo-sexually-oriented porn sites. The bottomline is that if you think you’re getting digital sex and get naked on camera, you’re probably getting digitally exploited!

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Sites: Many pornographic sites are fronts for hackers, who use malicious Web-based code to try and extract personal information. Just by visiting a site, you are exposing yourself to spyware and Trojans.

P2P: Another very common way of getting porn as well as viruses. Many people share virus or Trojan-infected files renamed to look like pornographic pictures or videos.

What Can We Do?

This is the question most parents are asking. The answer is simple: you need to first educate yourselves. Only then you can go about protecting your children. The simplest solution is to use content blockers, popularly referred to as porn blockers or parental control software. These content blockers will restrict your children to the “clean Web” and block all pornographic sites, images and videos from being viewed on your home computer.

The settings for such software are protected by passwords, so children cannot bypass the rules you set. Of course, there are chances that some safe content will also be blocked, but I think this is a risk most of us would willingly take.

Some software, which we’ll get to shortly, also let you set various levels of filtering, depending on the age of your kids. So use a “paranoid” setting for your 10-year-old, and a “low” setting for your 17-year-old.

In Conclusion

It’s scary! A majority of the parents we spoke to for this piece had no real knowledge about adult content and how it can be controlled or blocked. A lot of these people, not named here for reasons of privacy, have no real clue about how to use computers, or, more importantly, how their *kids* use computers. Perhaps we really are to blame for all those MMS scandals, simply because most of us don’t know enough about the technology!

The analogue generation of yesterday seems shocked by technology and the way it is—or can be—used by the digital generation of today. The rapid growth of technology and the way it’s woven itself into our lives seems to have caused more of a continental drift than just a generation gap.

Thankfully, the kids of today will not be as shell-shocked by whatever technology comes in tomorrow, so *right now* seems to be the worst. The only plausible solution to the porn problem is to get yourself a content blocker, and make sure your kids or younger siblings are not exposed to content online that may adversely affect their outlook in the most defining years of their lives.

Don’t worry—we will all weather the storm. All we need to do is be positive, be open to conversation about the subject, and be strict! I just hope this article opens more eyes than it closes!

Enough theory; let’s take a look at some of the software that’s available and how they performed when I actually used them. I stress-tested the software by trying to find porn with them running. I will talk about each software individually, in alphabetical order.

